Key Concepts of Conversation Analysis (CA)

An overview of CA's conceptualization of talk-in-interaction

Work in Progress

Visualized
CA
Concepts

This work in progress is an attempt to visualize the key concepts of ethnomethodological conversation analysis and how those concepts model naturally occurring human talk. The structuring and segmentation aim to facilitate a basic understanding of the granularity of the concepts (the macro and micro structures of talk) and how they relate to each other. The brief characterizations accompanying each node of the map serve to provide an initial understanding or a quick refresher.
Tip: For a more detailed discussion click on the title of each concept box to navigate to the respective article in the EMCA Wiki. Please be aware that currently not all concepts are covered by articles in the Wiki.

Feedback and suggestions for improvements are welcome! (see contact data below)

Color Legend

Observable	Phenomena, which are directly oberservable/measurable: The sound produced by the interactants, the words they utter, their gazes, accompanying physical activities, silences etc.
Cognitive	Phenomena manifesting as cognitive processes only discernible by carefully analyzing the conduct of the interactants.
Repair	Concepts and processes dealing with detecting and solving interactional problems.

Level of Detail[1]

CA Concepts

Conversation
between two or more participants

Activity
Some coordinated undertaking providing coherence to an interaction

Participants in a conversation are often engaged in a (social) activity, potentially aimed at achieving a specific outcome or goal. In this context, 'activity' can refer to anything from playing a board game or eating breakfast to making an emergency call or standing in court. Depending on the nature of the activity, some or all of it may be accomplished solely through talk.

frames or shapes

Conversational Project
Some covert goal or course of action

Besides easily recognizable „activities“ (see concept), there are less overt conversational „projects“ or courses of action that one or more participants may be pursuing. Some of these pursuits never fully surface. If in the preamble leading up to them, it already becomes clear, that they will be rejected, they may be silently abandoned. Typical examples are extending an invitation or asking for a favor. Some other projects may be tried repeatedly and successfully blocked or evaded by the other party, for example provoking certain statements in a news interview. Participants are generally attentive to such covert pursuits and will orient to them once they become apparent.

influences the course of

Talk-in-Interaction
Naturally occuring talk

Natural human conversation unfolds in real time, turn by turn, as a collaborative effort by the participants. Split-second phenomena can significantly influence the progression of the conversation. These moment-to-moment dynamics are highly contextual and mostly oblique to the participants.

structures and informs

Overall structural organization
Macro structures of a single occasion of talk

Examining the 'overall structural organization' of a conversation usually involves examining interactional units that extend beyond a single coherent sequence of utterances. Typical examples include the opening and closing parts of a conversation, as well as the conversation as a whole. This 'supra-sequential' perspective provides insights into how these larger segments structure and inform the progression of the conversation. For instance, an opening typically begins with a greeting sequence and ends with a transition to the first topic. Another focus point of this macro view are coherences of smaller elements that are not “local” to their respective sequences. 'How are you?', for example, does different things depending on whether it is part of the opening or the main part of a conversation.

if in a constrained “institutional” context

Institutional Talk
Talk shaped by particular conventions and expectations

Some interactions occur in an “institutional” context, where they are more rigidly shaped than ordinary or „casual“ conversations. An extreme example is a court hearing, where deviations from the established rules of interaction can be formally punishable. Other examples include news interviews, medical visitations and customer service calls. These situations share the characteristic features of „institutional talk“: Participants orient towards a specific task, goal or function associated with the institution. In addition, there are specific constraints on what contributions are acceptable, shaped by the participants' roles (e.g. patient and doctor). Also, the conduct and contributions of the participants may be interpreted differently compared to ordinary talk (e.g. adversarial questions in a news interview).

A coherent
String of Utterances[2]

Sequence Organization
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

Preference Organization
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

shapes

Sequence
A sequence of turns by alternating speakers

Some concise information

mostly consists of variants and extensions of

Intersubjectivity
Shared understanding of the participants

Some concise information

continously validates

Adjacency Pair
Two-part exchange (initial first and replying second part)

Some concise information

supports

Next Turn Proof Procedure
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

affects sequence organization

can uncover

Affecting
Both levels

Epistemics
The distribution and the rights to knowledge

How knowledgeable participants are relative to each other (regarding the current topic of conversation) plays a major role in shaping their turns at talk and the sequential progression of the conversation. For example, when giving a diagnosis, a doctor will present the same information differently to a patient than to another medical expert. Sharing exciting news will fizzle abruptly, if it turns out that the others are already aware of it. Additionally, participants actively monitor and defend their 'domains of knowledge', such as personal experiences, social affiliations and areas of expertise.

informs

Recipient Design
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

(Conversation) Trouble
Some Subtitle

See Schegloff 2007 & Sacks 1974

attempts to resolve

Repair (in same turn or subsequent turns)
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

affects turn design

A single
Utterance[2]

Current speaker

Current Recipients

Action Formation
TODO – The particular way a recognizable action is “expressed”

TODO Schegloff 2007, p. xiv, p. 263

serves to achieve

Turn Design
Speakers can employ a wealth of resources to construct their turn-at-talk

Speakers have a wide range of resources at their disposal to produce a nuanced situated turn-at-talk. These resources include choice of words, grammatical structures, prosody (such as intonation), timing (such as brief pauses), laughter, aspiration, gaze, gestures and body orientation. What a speaker does with these resources in a specific turn is primarily shaped by three aspects: The preceding turn, the intended recipient(s), and the social action(s) that the speaker aims to accomplish.

enables early start of

Projection
Predicting the course of the current turn and what is needed next

While listening, participants continuously monitor the current turn-at-talk in its production and project what action, by whom and when becomes (possibly) relevant.

aims to deliver

happens before and during

informs

Turn -at-talk
A single occasion to contribute to an interaction

Some concise information

observes production of current

Turn-Taking
The organization of who speaks next and when

The organization of turn-taking enables frequent and fluent speaker changes with minimized gaps and overlap. The next speaker can either be selected by the current speaker, self-select or the current speaker may continue speaking.

is comprised of one or more

watches for

Action
Talk is (social) action: What is done?

Saying words is not merely exchanging information. Making a request, offering help or rejecting an invitation are all (social) actions achieved through language. So the question is, what is being done by a particular turn at talk? Although multiple actions can be realized by even a single TCU, the “primary action” is usually seen as what the response must deal with in order to count as an adequate next turn.

constitutes one or more

TCU (Turn Constructional Unit)
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

can mark a potential

TRP (Transition Relevance Place)
A point where a change of speaker is relevant or possible

Some concise information

recipients continuously analyse what is done by the turn

Action Ascription
Some Subtitle

Some concise information

informs

Projection

Turn-Taking

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[1] The terms in this column are purely illustrative and not part of the CA terminology.
[2] For the sake of simplicity, “utterance” is meant here in the broadest sense possible as any recognizable contribution to a sequence of interaction, including but not limited to speech, non-verbal utterances, gestures and facial expressions.

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Created by Hans-Joachim Belz (2024).
Download latest version at https://github.com/hjbelz/visualized-CA/blob/main/current/visual-ca-concepts.pdf – use link “Download raw file”.
Feedback, suggestions and ideas are very welcome. Create a ticket at Github, contact me at Linkedin (https://www.linkedin.com/in/hansjoachimbelz/) or write to hans-joachim.belz[at]anstrengungslos.de.